

Making a mockery of weight classes

Islam Makhachev walked into the welterweight division without hesitation and spent five rounds showing why size matters far less than **timing, balance and intent.**

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UFC 322 was defined by dominant grappling performances in the championship bouts and electrifying knockouts across the main card. Islam Makhachev's move from lightweight to welterweight proved successful, while Valentina Shevchenko cemented her technical brilliance by defending her flyweight belt for the second time this year.

The main event showcased a clear tactical masterclass by the challenger, Makhachev, against reigning champion Jack Della Maddalena.

Makhachev's strategy was simple yet effective: negate Della Maddalena's dangerous boxing by immediately closing the distance and

leaning on superior wrestling. The defining factor was the timing of his takedowns. Makhachev consistently initiated grappling exchanges before the champion, a pure striker, could establish his range or build any offensive rhythm.

Once on the canvas, Makhachev's top control and positional awareness were flawless. He demonstrated the Dagestani style of riding his

opponent, denying Della Maddalena any room to create scrambles or attempt to stand. He mixed in ground and pound to maintain control and keep chipping away, resulting in a blowout on the scorecards (50-45 across the board).

Makhachev's dominance in the grappling exchanges nullified any lingering questions about his ability to transition and maintain control at 170 pounds.

Still the champ

The co-main event was a textbook display of technical brilliance by champion Shevchenko.

Shevchenko's game plan focused on mixing her disciplines to keep the aggressive Zhang Weili guessing. In the striking exchanges, "Bullet" used range control and counterstriking, tagging Zhang from the outside.

The critical turning point in each round came

Dominant ascent: Islam Makhachev soaks in the moment after dismantling Jack Della Maddalena to claim the UFC welterweight crown at Madison Square Garden, a performance that underlined his seamless rise across weight classes. GETTY IMAGES

